The Backup Conversation

How to ask Mom and the people around her who could really do what, and how to write down each answer.

“If it came to that, Aunt Carol would step in.” Everyone in the family has said it at one time or another. Whether anyone has said it to Aunt Carol is a different matter.

This guide is for one unhurried conversation, or a few short ones, with one job: hear from each person what they can really do for Mom, and write down what they said. It isn't for deciding anything, and nobody has to say yes.

Who should be in the conversation

Mom, first. It's her week, and who she'd want asked is hers to say. Then the people who help now: the neighbor who drives, your brother, you. Then the people whose names come up as backup. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which may mean a family friend or a neighbor as well as relatives. [1]

It doesn't have to be one meeting. A phone call with Aunt Carol and a chat with the neighbor at her front door both count, as long as someone writes down what was said. Pick one person to keep the notes.

How to open

Start with what's working, and start with a question. The National Institute on Aging says this kind of conversation is most productive when there is not an emergency, which is the kind of week you're in. [2]

- “Mom, the way your week runs works well. We'd like to write down who does what, so none of us is guessing. Would you go through it with us?”
- “Aunt Carol, your name comes up whenever we talk about who else could drive Mom to an appointment. Nobody has ever asked you, so I'm asking. Is that something you'd be open to?”
- Say what the conversation is for: knowing what each person can really do. Say what it isn't for: changing anything about Mom's week, or signing anyone up.
- Say at the start that “no” and “I'd have to think about it” are fine answers.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. Here's who we think does what in your week. What have we got wrong, or left off?

2. If one of us couldn't do our part for a while, who would you be comfortable with us asking? Is there anyone you'd rather we didn't?

Ask each person who helps now

1. What does your part involve, including the bits nobody else sees?

2. Is there any piece of it that only you know how to do?

3. The last time you couldn't do it, what happened?

Ask each person named as a backup

1. Which parts would you be comfortable taking on, and on which days? Which would you rather not?

2. Is there anything you'd want to see or be shown before you gave an answer?

Ask each other

1. What kind of change, in Mom's routine or in one of ours, would bring us back to this page?

How to write down what was said

Write each answer the way it was given, with who said it and when. Keep Mom's own account separate from everyone else's. Write an open line plainly, as something still to ask and not as something wrong. Where two people remember an arrangement differently, write both and don't settle it.

THE TASK	WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT, AND WHEN	STILL OPEN
Rides to appointments	“I could do a Tuesday or a Thursday afternoon. Not mornings, I work until noon.”	Aunt Carol, on the phone, Sunday	Who else could do a morning?
The evening phone call	“I like that it's you. If you can't, your brother can call, but tell me first.”	Mom, Sunday	

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What not to decide yet

Nothing has to be settled today. Some of these are Mom's to decide, and some need a professional who assesses her. Leave them open.

- Whether Mom's arrangement is enough.
- Whether to add help or change anything about her week.
- Who should have offered, or who does the most.
- Which of two memories is the right one.
- Anything about her health or her medications.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone, Mom included.
- Who will talk to the people who weren't part of it.
- When you'll look at the page again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, talk anyone into anything, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets each person's own answer onto one page, with the open lines left open.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked the people the family was counting on, and their answers are on one page with Mom's at the top. The care interview takes that page through her daily life area by area, so the parts nobody thought to raise come up too, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities